FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Unless you have been living under a rock, you will know about Artificial Intelligence (AI). Every era has a technology that rearranges the world. But AI is unlike any that came before. Earlier technologies, from the wheel to the computer, extended human capacity. This one has begun to simulate it. It is not only an accelerator but also a force that alters. Two years ago, in January 2024, we devoted a New Year's special issue to AI, at a moment when it was still largely experimental. The breakout version of ChatGPT was barely a year old. Large Language Models (LLMs) were still the dominant paradigm. By 2026, the frontiers of AI have expanded way beyond chatbots and clever prompts. It is moving decisively towards systems that plan, coordinate and act; models that learn continuously; machines that see, hear and reason across language, images and data. This is the phase where AI starts to manage workflows, write code, optimise factories, influence elections, extend credit, diagnose illness and personalise, as well as impersonate, reality itself.

This acceleration is unfolding at a time of global uncertainty, marked by geopolitical fragmentation, climate stress, demographic shifts and armed conflicts. AI is becoming both a multiplier of risk and a lever of possibility. The question is no longer whether it will transform our lives, but how deeply, how unevenly, and to whose advantage. For India, this is a moment of inflection. AI use is sweeping across India, seeping into all its corners, from Tier-2 cities to villages. With hundreds of millions of users, a mobile-first culture and a digital public infrastructure unmatched in scale, the choices India makes now, be it on data, governance, language, labour or ethics, will determine whether AI deepens inequality or becomes a genuine instrument of inclusion and growth.



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This special issue sets out to examine those frontiers and fault lines. It looks at how AI is remaking offices and factories, art and medicine, banking and cinema, classrooms and courtrooms; how it is redrawing power between citizens and platforms, states and corporations; and how it forces us to confront fundamental questions about autonomy, accountability and the limits of automation itself. Above all, it asks what it will take to ensure that intelligence amplified by machines does not come at the cost of human judgement, dignity and democratic choice.

We have leading policymakers, technologists, industry leaders and scholars to examine how India is placed at this turning point. Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union minister of electronics and information technology, sets the policy horizon, outlining how the Narendra Modi government intends to build sovereign AI capabilities at scale. Fellow IITian and former Union minister Jayant Sinha widens the lens, warning that without deep private investment, India risks slipping into a new era of techno-colonialism, especially as both AI models and the electric power needed to drive them guzzle trillions of dollars. Arun Srinivas of Meta argues that India's mobile-first ecosystem and digital rails give it a realistic chance to lead, not follow, the global AI revolution.

A clutch of essays offers fascinating insights on how industry is driving and ingesting the change. Rohan Murty, founder of Workfabric AI, introduces the idea of 'multiplayer AI', where intelligent systems coordinate teams rather than merely assist individuals. Hyundai India director Gopalakrishnan C.S. tells us how data-based tech is now interlaced with the entire value chain of modern auto manufacturing, from "digital pre-assembly and virtual simulations", to automated "dark factories" that feature cobots or collaborative robots, to testing, maintenance and customer engagement.

While the threat of job loss gets a lot of attention, it is often missed how AI meets social needs. In finance, quantum scientist Utpal Chakraborty describes a quiet but profound shift from human judgement based on paperwork to algorithmic assessment of behaviour and context, expanding access to credit for those long excluded. Microsoft's Kalika Bali focuses on Indian-language AI, perhaps the most consequential frontier of all, as it could bring millions of first-time users into the AI universe while reshaping the technology itself in the process.

Many of the essays alert us to the perils, in heightened focus after the recent controversy over sexualised deepfake images on Grok. Touching on that, Urvashi Aneja, founder-director, Digital Futures Lab, turns the conversation towards the danger of handing over all decision-making powers to Big Tech. Legal scholar Chinmayi Arun concurs, questioning how we take "Big Tech's AI products as inevitable, eliding other forms technological progress can take". Former Stanford Internet Observatory head Renée DiResta expands the question to democracy itself, looking at the role of deepfakes in Indian elections.

Only a society afraid to evolve will shun a technology so full of possibilities. But only a mindless one will outsource its consciousness, and conscience, to it. As Carnatic maestro T.M. Krishna reminds us in a thoughtful meditation on art and AI, we should not forget that "there is something unique about us, organic beings who recognise and understand the self". This issue is not an argument for or against Artificial Intelligence. It is an invitation to think clearly about how much of ourselves we are willing to automate and how much we must consciously preserve.

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